

Korea Daily Brief

Tuesday, September 15, 2026

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RE: Kim vows 'sacred war' support for Russia · KCNA confirms Sep 12 multi-type nuclear firepower drill · Lee-Kazakhstan summit; Central Asia summit week · ROK-Japan defense ministers videoconference

KOSPI
6,627.26
▼ -0.8%

USD/KRW
1,359.95
▲ +1.1%

BRENT
\$101.83
▼ -3.6%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Kim Jong Un sent a personal message to Putin backing Russia's Ukraine war as a 'sacred war' and pledging to expand bilateral ties ahead of Russia's parliamentary election, the most explicit public endorsement since DPRK troops deployed.
- 2 KCNA confirmed the September 12 launches were a multi-type nuclear firepower drill — three missile types plus drones — ending two days of silence and formally framing the exercise as nuclear in character.
- 3 President Lee Jae-myung upgraded ROK-Kazakhstan ties to 'future-oriented comprehensive strategic partnership' as the first ROK-Central Asia summit convened in Seoul, with Hyundai Engineering signing a 4 trillion-won gas facility deal on the sidelines.

• TOP STORIES

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

Kim Jong Un calls Ukraine war a 'sacred war,' vows to expand Russia ties ahead of Russian parliamentary election

Kim Jong Un sent a personal letter to **Vladimir Putin** — dated Monday, responding to Putin's congratulatory telegram on the DPRK founding anniversary — declaring unwavering support for Russia in what he termed a 'sacred war' and pledging to expand bilateral ties. Reuters also reported Kim's message, citing KCNA. The letter comes as Russia heads into parliamentary elections and days after KCNA confirmed the September 12 multi-type nuclear firepower drill, placing Kim's political messaging in direct sequence with his military signaling.

NK News / Reuters, Sep 15 2026

DPRK

KCNA confirms September 12 launches as multi-type nuclear firepower drill — three missile types plus drones

KCNA ended two days of post-launch silence by officially characterizing the September 12 launches as a 'concentrated strike drill' demonstrating 'huge destructive power,' involving multiple ballistic missile types and drones. AP reported KCNA described the exercise as showcasing the capability to conduct nuclear counterstrikes. The drill came one day after the US-Japan-ROK trilateral Freedom Edge 26 exercise concluded (Sep 7-11), consistent with the DPRK pattern of post-allied-exercise live-fire responses.

The Diplomat / AP / Reuters / NK News, Sep 15 2026

US-KOREA

More than 300 South Korean workers challenge Trump administration over Georgia immigration raid

CNN reports *more than 300* South Korean workers are legally challenging the Trump administration following an immigration enforcement raid in Georgia that targeted their workplace. The workers are contesting the action, the details of which CNN describes as an exclusive. The case emerges against the backdrop of the US-Korea Strategic Investment Deal, which channels billions of dollars of Korean manufacturing to US states including Georgia.

CNN (exclusive), Sep 15 2026

• OVERNIGHT

BUSINESS	South Korea finance minister nominee says economy is at a 'turning point' · Bloomberg Lee Hyung-il made the statement at his National Assembly hearing.
TECHNOLOGY	South Korea to develop new security guidelines for autonomous AI agents · Reuters Guidelines will cover agentic AI systems operating without direct human control.
DPRK	US court orders North Korea and Iran to pay \$487M to 47 American victims of terrorist attacks · NK News Eastern District of Virginia ruling issued September 8.
US-KOREA	[Exclusive] US proposes pyroprocessing investment for 4,000 tons of spent nuclear fuel — already past \$200B invested · 한겨레 Washington has proposed joint investment in pyroprocessing R&D as bilateral nuclear cooperation talks continue.
BUSINESS	Volatility surges in first after-hours session on Korea Exchange · Bloomberg VI triggered 1,112 times; exchange says volatility was lower than regular session.
DPRK	Yeonpyeong Sea Battle veterans and bereaved families file damages suit against North Korea and Kim Jong Un in Seoul court · 뉴시스 Total claim: 160 million won (20 million per plaintiff) for 8 claimants.

• STAT OF THE DAY

162조원

ROK Future Response Fund debated at finance minister confirmation hearing

Finance minister nominee Lee Hyung-il defended a proposed 162-trillion-won sovereign stabilization fund at his National Assembly confirmation hearing, with the ruling DP calling it a 'fiscal stabilizer' and PPP calling it discretionary slush.

뉴스스 — 이형일 청문회서 미래대응기금 공방

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN

WATCH FLAG

● No appearance (7d since last)

“Sacred war.”

Kim Jong Un — North Korea's Kim vows to expand ties with Russia, backs victory in 'sacred war' — Reuters/NK News

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. Kim Jong Un vows to expand ties with Russia, backs victory in 'sacred war' KIM

Kim sent a personal letter to Putin pledging unwavering support for Russia's Ukraine campaign, which he described as a 'sacred war,' and committing to expand DPRK-Russia bilateral ties ahead of Russia's parliamentary election. — Reuters (KCNA)

2. North Korea says September 12 missile launches were part of live-fire nuclear firepower drill demonstrating 'huge destructive power'

KCNA ended two days of post-launch silence by confirming the September 12 launches as a multi-type nuclear firepower drill involving ballistic missiles and drones, characterized as a concentrated strike exercise demonstrating nuclear counterattack capability. — AP (KCNA)

3. North Korea's politburo meeting hints at secret changes to senior officials KIM

An August 25 politburo meeting adopted 'political and practical measures' to complete annual goals, but state media withheld portions including apparent senior military reshuffling — with seating arrangement analysis suggesting command-level changes. — NK News (NK Pro)

Bottom line: Kim Jong Un's 'sacred war' letter to Putin is the most explicit public endorsement of Russian military objectives since DPRK troops deployed; combined with KCNA's formal confirmation of the September 12 multi-type nuclear firepower drill, the DPRK is simultaneously escalating political alignment with Moscow and nuclear military signaling — watch Punggye-ri and any new KCNA output as Kim remains absent from state media for seven days.

● ROK GOVERNMENT

President + Ministries · Tuesday, September 15, 2026

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Lee upgrades ROK-Kazakhstan ties to 'future-oriented comprehensive strategic partnership'

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Lee holds summit with Turkmenistan president on energy and plant cooperation

President Lee Jae-myung

President Lee met Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev at Cheong Wa Dae and announced a bilateral relationship upgrade. The summit coincided with the first ROK-Central Asia summit and Hyundai Engineering's signing of a 4-trillion-won gas facility deal with the Kazakh state gas company.

Primary [뉴스](#) ↗

President Lee Jae-myung

Lee met Turkmenistan President Serdar Berdimuhamedov and discussed cooperation in shipbuilding, railways, smart cities, defense, water resources, and ICT. Lee expressed gratitude to Turkmenistan for assisting the evacuation of Korean nationals from Iran.

Primary [SBS](#) ↗

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

ROK-Japan defense ministers hold videoconference; agree on stable bilateral defense cooperation

Defense Minister Ahn Gyu-baek

Defense Minister Ahn Gyu-baek and Japan Defense Minister Koizumi Shinjiro conducted a videoconference — the first minister-level dialogue since a bilateral defense ministers' meeting in Seoul in late June. Both sides reaffirmed the importance of ROK-Japan and ROK-US-Japan cooperation for peninsula and regional peace, and agreed on the need to advance 'reciprocal and future-oriented' defense exchanges despite recent tensions over Yasukuni visits.

Primary [뉴스](#) ↗

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Kim Bu-gyeom **NOMINATED**

Chair, National Unity Commission (국민통합위원장)

Cheong Wa Dae is in final review of former Prime Minister Kim Bu-gyeom as the next chair of the Presidential Committee on National Unity, following the departure of the previous chair after a one-year term. Kim, a four-term lawmaker and former Prime Minister under the Moon administration, is regarded as a cross-regional unifying figure having won in the conservative Daegu constituency.

Replaces: Lee Seok-yeon (이석연)

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Confirmation hearing for Justice Minister nominee Kim Seung-won — no witnesses, key allegations unresolved

Legislation and Judiciary Committee (법제사법위원회)

The hearing ended without resolving allegations of a COVID-19 drug clinical-trial lobbying scandal or family-related preferential treatment. No witnesses were called after the ruling DP blocked their adoption. Nominee Kim signaled he would investigate alleged political use of prosecution records by independent lawmaker Han Dong-hoon if confirmed.

Confirmation hearing for SME Minister nominee Lee So-young — DP backs as 'most suitable'; PPP cites lack of SME legislation

DP members highlighted Lee's background supporting small business recovery funding; PPP members noted she had passed zero SME-related legislation during her Assembly tenure. Allegations of non-residence property and consultancy payments to empty firms were also raised.

• US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff in effect. Section 301 investigations — launched March 11 against South Korea and 15 other partners — are now the primary vehicle for any future broad tariff action.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now the primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE

next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES

Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

• BUSINESS & ECONOMY

TECH · 한국경제

KT to invest 6 trillion won in AI data centers over five years

KT announced a 6-trillion-won five-year commitment to AI data center infrastructure — adding to the broader Korean telco buildout that includes SKT's 2GW Vera Rubin facility tied to the NVIDIA LOI from July 2026.

KT

MANUFACTURING · 한국경제

Hyosung Heavy Industries wins 380 billion won ultra-high-voltage transformer order from the US

380 billion won in ultra-high-voltage transformers ordered from the US — consistent with Korean grid equipment firms supplying the AI-driven US power infrastructure buildout.

Hyosung Heavy Industries

MANUFACTURING · 동아일보

POSCO labor talks collapse; union announces 120-hour second partial strike from September 16

POSCO's union is demanding a 7.1% base-pay rise and 600% bonus; management offered 2.0% and a 3.5-million-won incentive. CEO Lee Hee-geun attended negotiations directly but no deal was reached; management proposed talks through September 18.

POSCO

• NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

JAPAN-KOREA · JAPAN-DEFENSE · 동아일보

ROK-Japan defense ministers hold videoconference; agree on stable defense cooperation despite Yasukuni tensions

Defense Minister **Ahn Gyu-baek** and Japan Defense Minister **Koizumi Shinjiro** conducted a videoconference, their first high-level exchange since the late-June Seoul bilateral meeting. Japan had already signaled its non-attendance at the ministerial level for the Seoul Security Dialogue (Sep 7-9) — sending a lower-level delegate — after Yasukuni visit controversy; the videoconference represents a repair attempt.

CHINA-KOREA · CHINA-DIPLOMATIC · 한겨레

ROK-Kazakhstan summit upgrades bilateral ties; Hyundai Engineering signs 4 trillion-won gas facility deal at Karachaganak

President **Lee Jae-myung** met Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev and elevated the relationship to 'future-oriented comprehensive strategic partnership' — the first such upgrade. The summit formed part of the inaugural ROK-Central Asia summit in Seoul, with Hyundai Engineering signing a Karachaganak gas processing facility agreement with Kazakhstan's state gas company KazMunayGas.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

RULING
Democratic

OPPOSITION
People Power

INDEPENDENTS

38%

▼ 2 pts vs Sep 4

Gallup Korea · week of 2026-09-11

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 38% across 3 readings

39%

25%

26%

Gallup Korea Spotlight August 25-27, 2026

Security Policy and Military Reform: Lee Jae-myung's approval stood at 42% (lowest since inauguration) with disapproval first crossing 50%, surveyed August 25-27; the spotlight covered OPCON transfer, denuclearization, inter-Korean military balance, and a proposed merger of the three military academies.

Discourse: 매일경제 reports President Lee is scheduling a 90-minute press conference on September 18 amid polling at a post-inauguration low (Realmeter showing 33.8%), with expected focus on Hormuz Strait deployment, cabinet nominations, and constitutional amendment to allow re-election.

• UPCOMING

Oct
1

ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

NK NEWS

NK News op-ed: North Korea's Rodong Sinmun references to Taiwan in 2026 carry strategic implications for the US

Pacific Forum's Rob York argues that DPRK state media mentions of Taiwan signal Pyongyang's alignment with a broader anti-US axis narrative, complicating Washington's multi-front deterrence posture.

BUSINESS

FEDERAL REGISTER

Federal Register: Final countervailing duty review on Oil Country Tubular Goods from South Korea (2023 review)

The US Commerce Department published final CVD administrative review results and partial rescission for Korean OCTG — a standing trade remedy that adds to Korean steel exporters' cost burden on top of the Section 232 50% tariff.

ENERGY

BLOOMBERG

South Korea plans fewer transmission towers in electricity grid expansion

The government is revising grid expansion plans to reduce the number of high-voltage transmission towers, reflecting public opposition to infrastructure siting — a constraint on the buildout needed to support AI data center and semiconductor fab power demand.

ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

President Lee Jae-myung @Jaemyung_Lee

“투르크메니스탄의 풍부한 자원과 대한민국의 기술과 경험을 바탕으로 새로운 협력의 지평을 넓혀가겠습니다. 특히 지난해와 올해 중동의 엄중한 상황에서 이란에 머물던 우리 국민과 가족들이 안전하게 대피할 수 있도록 도와주신 데 다시 한번 깊이 감사드립니다.”

Context: Lee posted after his summit with Turkmenistan President Berdimuhamedov on September 15, publicly thanking Turkmenistan for assisting Korean nationals evacuating Iran during the regional crisis — signaling the breadth of ROK-Central Asia engagement beyond economic diplomacy.

[View on X →](#)

US Ambassador to ROK @USAmbROK

“Having served in Congress myself, I have a deep appreciation for the National Assembly and its role in the ROK's remarkable democratic and economic development. Thank you, Chairman Kim Min-Seok and Chairman Jang Dong-hyeok, for the warm welcome and thoughtful conversations today.”

Context: The US Ambassador's meeting with both DP Chairman Kim Min-seok and PPP Chairman Jang Dong-hyeok on September 15 — also separately noted in a Sep 14 report on ambassador-vice FM implementation talks — suggests the embassy is actively briefing both major parties on summit agreement implementation as the political calendar becomes contentious.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Lee Jae-myung

President of the Republic of Korea

“우리 양국 관계를 미래지향적 포괄적 전략적 동반자 관계로 격상하고 양국 간 협력을 한층 심화시켜 나가게 될 것.”

Analyst: Lee made the statement at the ROK-Kazakhstan summit at Cheong Wa Dae on September 15, the first ROK-Central Asia summit, positioning Kazakhstan as a critical mineral and energy partner amid global supply chain restructuring.

[Source →](#)



Ahn Gyu-baek

ROK Minister of National Defense

“상호 이해와 신뢰에 기반한 호혜적·미래지향적인 한일 국방 교류협력의 안정적 추진 필요성에 대해 인식을 같이했다.”

Analyst: Ahn's statement after the Sep 15 videoconference with Japan Defense Minister Koizumi Shinjiro — the first defense minister dialogue since late June — explicitly acknowledges the need to stabilize exchanges amid recent Yasukuni-related friction that led Japan to send a lower-level delegate to the Seoul Security Dialogue.

[Source](#) →

COMMENTARY

IISS

South Korea should help defend Ukraine's skies

The IISS piece argues that ROK capabilities — in particular ground-based air defense systems — are directly relevant to Ukraine's needs and that Seoul's continued restraint on lethal aid carries strategic costs in terms of alliance credibility and deterrence precedent. The argument is framed against the backdrop of North Korean troops fighting alongside Russian forces in Ukraine.

• SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

NBC NEWS · SEP 15, 2026 — NK-RUSSIA AND NK-CHINA BRIDGE ANALYSIS

NBC News examines the parallel openings of the NK-Russia Tumen River road bridge and the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong new Yalu River crossing, framing them as dual infrastructure bets.

NBC News published an analysis of two new border crossings — the Tumen River road bridge between North Korea and Russia (opened Sep 8, named after Yakov Novichenko) and the new Yalu River bridge between Sinuiju and Dandong assessed as near-opening by 38 North satellite imagery (Sep 11). The piece frames the dual infrastructure as North Korea simultaneously deepening ties with both Moscow and Beijing. The Tumangang-Khasan bridge remains restricted to organized bus tours; the Sinuiju crossing, if opened, would restore direct rail-plus-road connectivity severed during COVID.

→ Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border) · Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

[NBC News — Two new bridges analysis](#) ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

ALERT ▲

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News

imagery as of 2026-09-10

analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)

Sep 11, 2026: 38 North satellite imagery analysis shows the new North Korea-China border crossing (new Yalu River Bridge) appears close to opening. Mar 12, 2026: Cross-border passenger train service resumed between Sinuiju and Dandong after COVID-era suspension. NBC News analysis (Sep 15) cites both crossings as signals of North Korea deepening ties with both Russia and China simultaneously.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail.

imagery as of 2026-09-08

7 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-05.

ON THIS DAY

September 15, 2021 North Korea fired two short-range missiles from Yangdok into the sea between Korea and Japan, flying approximately 800 kilometers.

Five years on, the DPRK has just confirmed a September 12, 2026 multi-type nuclear firepower drill involving missiles and drones — the pattern of post-trilateral-exercise launches in the September window continues.

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